

Appendix 1: The British Jazz Fan, 1958

A few thousand young Britons, of whom about half live in London and the Home Counties and thirty per cent in the London postal area, belong to the *National Jazz Federation* which undertakes various activities designed to foster jazz. It is reasonable to regard them as a cross-section of the community of British jazz enthusiasts, though not necessarily of the larger marginal jazz public. Thanks to the foresight of this organization, intending members are asked to state their occupation. The following information is based on a random sample of 820 filing cards. I am greatly obliged to Mr Harold Pendleton of the N.J.F. and to his colleagues for making these invaluable records available to me.

Only about sixty out of the 820 sample jazz enthusiasts are girls: the public of enthusiasts is overwhelmingly male. The remainder of this analysis is therefore confined to the boys and young men, for though no ages are given, it is evident that virtually all N.J.F. members are young. There are too few girls to allow us to draw any conclusions about their occupations and social classes, but as we might expect, the majority seem to be office workers and shop assistants, with a sprinkling of students, nurses, and technicians.

‘Occupation’ for most jazz fans means ‘future occupation’, since so many of them are still being educated, apprenticed, or trained, and many are in military service. Where a precise civilian occupation is indicated, I have listed it: i.e. when a card says ‘soldier, civilian occupation clerk’ it has been counted as clerk; when it says ‘architectural student’ it has been counted among architects and not students. However, this still leaves several imprecise occupational labels, e.g. ‘student’, which may well include a number of school children or the troublesome ‘engineer’, which may indicate anything between a fitter’s mate and a future civil engineer. The following table, which lists the main occupational groups in order of size, is therefore rather rough-and-ready. Since this book is not addressed

to specialist sociologists, I have cut technical notes and explanations to the minimum.

Occupations of Male Members of N.J.F.

I.	TOTAL NUMBER	758
II.	UNCLASSIFIABLE	
1.	Schoolboys and students	91
2.	Occupation unstated	59
3.	National service and armed forces (<i>a</i>)	39
III.	CLASSIFIABLE OCCUPATIONS	
4.	Engineers and electricians (<i>b</i>)	120
5.	Clerks (incl. bank clerks)	105
6.	Other skilled workers: <i>Printing trades</i> (<i>c</i>)	33
	<i>Building trades</i> (<i>d</i>)	23
	<i>Other skilled workers</i>	17 73
7.	Draughtsmen, surveyors, etc.	36
8.	Business and commerce (<i>e</i>)	32
9.	Transport (<i>f</i>)	25
10.	Scientific workers (<i>g</i>)	23
11.	Semi-and unskilled workers (<i>h</i>)	25
12.	Technologists and technicians (<i>i</i>)	21
13.	Higher engineering (<i>j</i>)	17
14.	Artists, writers, journalists, advertising, etc.	15
15.	Civil servants, local government, etc.	12
16.	Accountants	11
17.	Mining, iron and steel	9
18.	Post and telegraph (<i>k</i>)	9
19.	Photographers	6
20.	Articled clerks	5
21.	Teachers, social workers, librarian	5
22.	Agricultural and forestry	4

23. Policemen	3
24. Doctors and dentists	2
25. Miscellaneous	11

Notes:

(a) Regular and national servicemen cannot be distinguished. Probably 'Occupation unstated' includes several conscripts.

(b) This includes all who describe themselves as engineers, electricians, unless there is reason to believe that they belong to Group 13, and all who describe themselves as *fitter, turner, toolmaker, radar-tester, shuttle-maker* or the like, or as apprentice to any such trades.

(c) Compositors (the largest group), 'printers', lithographers, process engravers, etc. Virtually all seem to be skilled.

(d) The usual building trades, among whom carpenter/joiners and plumbers are the most numerous.

(e) Salesmen, commercial travellers, buyers, shop managers, shopkeepers, insurance brokers, and the like, a few shop assistants.

(f) Including 11 motor drivers, 5 railwaymen—4 of them signalmen—6 Covent Garden porters, draymen, lightermen, and the like.

(g) 8 lab. assistants/technicians, 5 research workers, 10 'chemists' and 'physicists' not describing themselves as research workers.

(h) A very miscellaneous group.

(i) All who describe themselves as such and a few others such as *mining student, apprentice metallurgist*, and the like.

(j) All who describe themselves as *student engineer*, or in sufficiently specialized terms, e.g. *civil, work study, production, textile design engineer*.

(k) A number of people belonging here have already been listed under Group 4. The rest are mainly telegraph operators.

This table may be summarized as follows:

1. The main bulk of the fans lies somewhere between the skilled workers, technicians, and technologists. Rather over 300 of the 539 people in Group III belong to this middle range, which may include groups 4, 6, 7, 10, 12, 13, 19, perhaps also 16 and 20. Even if we assume

that all the 73 students will eventually have different occupations, the middle range still covers almost half the sample.

2. Unskilled, semi-skilled, and dead-end occupations are remarkably rare. All, or nearly all, random samples of 60–80 cards contain at least one draughtsman, printer, or lab technician and a large handful of the ubiquitous engineers and electricians, but the lorry or van driver, porter and railwayman occur only sporadically, the labourer, factory worker, millhand, hardly at all.

3. Certain industries are remarkably under-represented. There is almost nobody from the textile and clothing trades (except a few attached engineers and technicians), from food and drink, and the general service industries. For instance: *printing and publishing*, which in 1954 employed 311,000 people, supplies about 40 jazz enthusiasts: *textile and clothing*, which employed 1,633,000 does not provide 5, apart from the technicians; *road transport and railways* (just over one million) provide 22, excluding clerks.

4. Among the non-technical and non-working-class group, we note the relatively high number of office workers, mostly clerks.

5. The students are comparatively well represented.

It is quite safe to conclude that the jazz enthusiasts as a group are distinctly above the national average in education, skill, and technical qualification, and abnormally well represented in the characteristic occupations of the twentieth century. The first part of this conclusion can be demonstrated by the following table, which compares the social class distribution of occupied males under twenty-five years of age in 1951 with that in our sample. The “social classes” of the census are rather odd categories, but they are all we have in the statistics. Roughly Class I includes the higher professions, directors, and higher managers; Class II the less well-paid professions, shopkeepers, farmers, etc.: Class III foremen and supervisory workers, black-coated workers, shop assistants, and skilled manual workers; Class IV semi-skilled; and Class V unskilled manual workers. As it is impossible to do so, I have made no attempt to separate Classes I and II, and Classes IV and V in the sample. Obviously, for reasons of age, very few members would be in Class I. How many will eventually end there nobody can tell.

Social classes in the population and among jazz fans: in approximate percentages

<i>Census Class</i>	<i>Occupied males under 25 years, 1951</i>	<i>N.J.F. sample 1958 (a)</i>
I and II	8	36
III	64	53
IV and V	<u>28</u>	<u>11</u>
Total	100	100

(a) All 73 students and the relevant occupational groups have been allocated to Classes I and II. As the allocation necessarily contains some guesswork, not too much should be read into the difference between the two columns of Class III, but the higher percentages for I and II, the lower one for IV and V, are beyond dispute. Schoolboys and servicemen have not been allocated to any class.

For those unused to reading statistical tables, this one shows (a) that the jazz fans contain a far higher percentage of people in Classes I and II than the national population of occupied young men, and (b) that they contain a far lower percentage of the semi-and unskilled.

These figures confirm the general account of the British jazz public in Chapter 10, which was written before I had seen them. Only one thing seems odd. The 'arts' people (as against the scientifically, technically and vocationally educated) clearly play a much smaller part in the *organized* jazz community than they did at one time in the general popularization of jazz. Where are all the art students, journalists, commercial artists, film technicians, actors, and general bohemians? Either they are no longer so important, or else they don't join organizations, even of jazz enthusiasts, other than jazz clubs, about whose social composition nothing reliable is known.